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ANKITA BHAKAT,28
International Recurve Archer, Olympian, Assistant Manager (Sports), Tata Steel
Kolkata

Hitting the Bull's-eye

Ankita Bhakat was just 10 when she accompanied her father to an archery ground in north Kolkata. Something clicked when she saw the bow and arrow. "I liked them and so I decided to learn archery," she says, recalling the moment that altered the course of her life. Her homemaker mother and her father, a milk trader, stood firmly behind her dream. But recurve archery is an expensive sport, and a professional bow costs over Rs 2 lakh. For six years, Ankita competed in the Indian Round discipline, a traditional format with wooden bows while looking for help to buy an Olympic recurve bow (one that curves away at the tips). Finally, in 2014, she was selected to the Tata Archery Academy in Jamshedpur, giving her world-class coaching and a recurve bow of her own.

Having made her international debut in 2015, Ankita's talent propelled her to the very top of India's recurve archery ranks. She hit the bullseye again and again: bronze at the Hangzhou Asian Games, representing India at the 2024 Paris Olympics, and, in 2025, a maiden individual Asian Championship title. In 2026, she was in the Indian team that defeated South Korea and China to win World Cup gold.

Employed in the sports department of Tata Steel, Ankita spends 6-8 hours daily on the range. Yet, despite the accolades won, she believes her biggest achievement still lies ahead. That little girl who fell in love with bows and arrows now dreams of standing on the highest step of an Olympic podium. ■

— Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

One of India's top recurve archers and a multiple World Cup medallist and Asian Games bronze winner, Ankita Bhakat overcame financial hardship and sporting odds to become an inspiration. Next target: The Olympics

HER TAKE

"Parents should encourage their children to play sports. And when children play, they should enjoy the sport instead of treating everything as a competition"